MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 3: Reading the Shakespearean Sonnet

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Reading a Shakespearean sonnet means following its crafted argument while keeping publication history and uncertain identities in view.

Start with a picture

A small box can contain a carefully arranged machine. Fourteen lines can likewise hold a sequence of comparisons, objections, turns, and conclusions. The small size does not mean the thought is simple.

1. A brief history

The sonnet developed in medieval Italy, associated particularly with Giacomo da Lentini and the Sicilian school, and became influential through Petrarch. Wyatt and Surrey helped adapt it to English. Spenser and Shakespeare developed further patterns.

Love is a major inherited subject, but the form can also explore religion, politics, grief, language, and artistic creation. Its versatility depends partly on how a limited structure concentrates argument.

2. Two important structures

A Petrarchan sonnet typically divides into an octave and sestet. An English or Shakespearean sonnet usually contains three quatrains and a couplet, rhyming ABAB CDCD EFEF GG.

The usual metre is **iambic pentameter**: five feet with a basic unstressed–stressed pattern. Natural speech and metrical variation make actual lines more flexible than ten equally mechanical syllables.

The **volta** is a turn in thought. It may begin a contrast, qualify a claim, or introduce a new perspective. Find the turn by reading the argument rather than counting to one compulsory line.

3. The 1609 Quarto

Thomas Thorpe published a collection of 154 numbered sonnets with A Lover’s Complaint. Some individual sonnets had appeared earlier. The collection’s publication does not itself establish exactly how Shakespeare authorised, ordered, or revised it.

The dedication to “Mr. W. H.” and its phrase “onlie begetter” have generated competing explanations. It is not secure evidence for one proven identification. Distinguish a dedicatee, an addressee within a poem, and the author; they are different roles.

4. Duncan-Jones’s intervention

Katherine Duncan-Jones challenges the simple picture of Thorpe as a disreputable pirate. She draws attention to publication conventions, Thorpe’s wider work, and thematic organisation. Her argument supports taking the volume’s arrangement seriously; it does not settle every historical uncertainty.

5. Conventional groupings and exceptions

Sonnets 1–126 are often grouped around a male addressee, while 127–154 are commonly associated with the Dark Lady, though the sequence is more varied than those labels imply. The rival-poet group and the concluding Cupid poems complicate a neat two-part biography.

Not every sonnet has the standard form: Sonnet 99 has fifteen lines; 126 has twelve lines in couplets; 145 uses tetrameter. Recognising exceptions makes the general pattern more accurate, not less useful.

6. Connect the four prescribed sonnets

18 and 55: verse offers remembrance against time and destruction, through natural and monumental imagery respectively.

130: extravagant comparisons are refused, and the couplet affirms a different basis for affection.

144: religious and sexual imagery frame suspicion, but do not establish the suspected events as fact.

Across them, ask how the speaker’s confidence changes and what the ending asks the reader to accept.

Quick check

1. Does “Mr. W. H.” prove a single identity? **No.**
2. Is every turn at line 9? **No.**
3. Are all 154 poems fourteen lines of pentameter? **No; there are notable exceptions.**

Build an exam answer

1. Distinguish personal effect from proven autobiography.

2. Explain form and the movement of thought.
3. Give examples from two prescribed sonnets.
4. Discuss Thorpe, the dedication, and Duncan-Jones.
5. Evaluate the usefulness and limits of conventional labels.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not identify the dedication’s recipient as settled fact, label every final couplet a simple conclusion, or ignore formal exceptions.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How do form and publication history complicate autobiographical readings of the sonnets?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The sonnets invite personal responses because their speakers express intense affection, jealousy, fear, and desire. Yet emotional immediacy does not establish a direct equivalence between speaker and author. The poems are crafted works arranged within a printed sequence whose historical circumstances remain partly uncertain. Interpretation should therefore attend to form and transmission as well as feeling.

The English-sonnet pattern organises thought through repeated quatrains and a closing couplet. A turn can redirect an apparent comparison, as in Sonnet 18, or change the force of earlier refusals, as in Sonnet 130. The speaker’s position emerges through this rhetorical movement. Treating the poem as a diary entry risks overlooking how its claim is produced by structural choices.

The 1609 volume also raises questions that cannot be answered by the lyric voice alone. Thorpe’s dedication and the uncertain identity of Mr. W. H. belong to the material publication, while the addressees imagined within poems occupy another level. Duncan-Jones’s argument against a simple piracy narrative encourages attention to conventions and arrangement without converting the unknown into certainty.

The familiar labels Fair Youth and Dark Lady can guide discussion, but they should not impose a complete factual story on diverse poems. A secure answer identifies the evidence for a reading and keeps its limits visible. Historical uncertainty need not prevent analysis: it makes the poem’s images, turns, and claims even more important as the evidence actually available.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Trace the brief history and general characteristics of the sonnet form.
2. Why is the sonnet form considered to be versatile?
3. Who were the early pioneers of the Sonnet genre in English?
4. What are the features of the ‘English sonnet’?
5. Explain the usage of iambic pentameter in the sonnet form.
6. What is the volta?
7. Describe the primary theme of sonnets across ages.
8. Briefly describe the history of the publication of Shakespeare’s sonnets.
9. What are Katherine Duncan-Jones’s views on the 1609 Quarto?
10. Write a short note on the questions raised by the dedication page of the Quarto.
11. Briefly describe the format followed by Shakespeare in composing his sonnets.
12. How are Shakespearean Sonnets popularly classified?
13. Compare and contrast the representation of the Fair Youth and the Dark Lady.
14. How are Sonnets 18 and 55 interconnected?
15. Describe the representation of the Dark Lady in Sonnet 130.
16. How does Sonnet 144 present the progression of the speaker’s relationship with the Fair Youth and the Dark Lady?